

A Case Study of Korea's Soft Power of K-Democracy in German-Speaking Countries

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1. Introduction:

South Korea (hereafter Korea) has come a long way the past 80 years regarding its economic and political development, evolving into an advanced country in a relatively short amount of time (Chang, 2022; Im, 2020). Nowadays Korea is most well-known internationally for its vibrant popular culture such as K-drama and K-pop that is consumed by audiences around the globe, a phenomenon that is usually described by the term Korean Wave or Hallyu (Kim, 2013, 2022). This global popularity of Korean popular culture is also often linked to a high soft power of Korea as a country (Kim, 2022).

The term *soft power* was originally coined by Joseph S. Nye, Jr. (2004) meaning the ability to shape the preferences of others and thus making them act in a way that is profitable to one's desired outcomes. In other words, soft power refers to the capability to attract others to a nation's ambitions through indirect ways such as culture rather than through hard power such as military or economic force (Nye, 2004; Nye, 2008). Although there can be nonstate actors wielding soft power, the term is usually used in context with foreign policy of nation states (Nye, 2004). According to Nye (2004, 2008), the soft power of a state is mainly dependent on following recourses: (1) its cultural appeal, (2) its political values, and (3) its foreign policies.

In the case of Korea, the Korean government is heavily involved in the global popularity of the Korean Wave, as it serves as a profound tool for its national branding inducing an image of Korea as a culturally rich and technology highly advanced country (Kim, 2013, 2022). As such, Korea's popular culture and its attractiveness can be seen as the primary focus of Korea's soft power. However, recently with the events of the candlelight

protests under the Park Geun-Hye regime from 2016 to 2017 (Chun, 2020) and the attempted coup d'état by former president Yoon Suk-Yeol back in early December 2024, Korea started to coin the term of K-democracy (K-민주주의), referring to the high resiliency – and in extension to the supposedly exemplary status – of its democratic system (Choi, 2025; Lee, 2024). Moreover, this term is not only used insight Korea but also as a tool to highlight Korea's positive image and political values on an international stage (Jeong, 2025, October 25; Kim, 2025, July 14). Thus, this can be seen as Korea expanding its soft power from solemnly cultural attractiveness driven by the Korean Wave to including desirable political values like an admirable democracy.

However, this discourse of a seemingly perfect democracy that is portrayed by the Korean government to the global arena stands in contradiction with recent research arguing that Korea is also subject to democratic backsliding, a phenomenon that can be observed in nation states all around the world (Eom & Kwon, 2023; Kwon, 2023; Waldner & Lust, 2018). According to Waldner and Lust (2018), democratic backsliding refers to the gradual erosion and discontinuity of fundamental characteristics of democracy. In the context of Korea, Kwon (2023) links the backsliding of democracy to the conjunction of the strong presidential and the winner-takes-all political system and the increasing emotional polarization of the Korean political landscape.

This contradiction of the notion of K-democracy as a soft power and Korea's sociopolitical reality begs the question of how Korea promotes K-democracy in the global context. While there has been studies about the Korean Wave as a potential soft power (Kim, 2022), research about K-democracy in this context has been limited and primarily elucidated the case of English-speaking countries such as the United States or the United Kingdom (Ha, 2025).

Hence, the purpose of this study is to explore the soft power of K-democracy by

analysing how German-speaking newspapers reported about the martial law incident of December 2024.

The reason for choosing German-speaking countries is because this region is the largest linguistic region in Europe, a continent where the popularity of Korean popular culture, and hence the potential soft power of Korea, is highly increasing for the last few years (2022 *Global Hallyu Trend*, 2022; Cho, 2021).

Moreover, by illuminating the case of German-speaking countries this research can be meaningful as it helps to understand how other states view Korea, as it pursues to expand its soft power from cultural attractiveness to political values.

2. Literature Review:

2.1. Overview of the History of Korea's Democratic Development

After Japan's defeat in the Pacific War and the thereafter liberation of the Korean peninsula, Korea regained its sovereignty after 35 years of Japanese colonialization and launched as a fully functional democracy regarding its legal foundation and institutions shortly after in the year 1948 (Chang, 2025b). However, albeit democratically elected, the first president of Korea, Rhee Syng-Man various times tried to manipulate elections and politics in his favour, aiming for his permanent rule of the country (Chang, 2025b; Kang, 2015). This endeavour outraged the Korean public leading to student-led demonstrations around the country resulting in the removal of Rhee Syng-Man in 1960 (Kang, 2015).

After Rhee Syng-Man was gone, a democratic government under president Yun Po-Sun was established (Chang, 2025b). This government, however, only lasted for roughly one year after it collapsed due to a military coup by Park Chung-Hee in May 1961, initiating 30 years of continuous reign by the military (Kang, 2015).

Throughout Park Chung-Hee's reign there had been protests against his authoritarian regime, however, it was not until the director of the Korean Central Intelligence Agency at

that time assassinated Park Chung-Hee in the October of 1979, that his totalitarian rule came to an end (Han, 2023; Kang, 2015; Lee & Kim, 2016).

Even after 18 years of dictatorial reign under Park Chung-Hee Korea was not free from military reign, as Chun Doo-Hwan seized power through another military coup after Park Chung-Hee's death in December of 1979 (Kang, 2015; Lee & Kim, 2016). It was not until sparking resistance of students, intellectuals etc. that Chun Doo-Hwan was forced to step down in 1987 and reinstall democratic procedures such as the direct election of the president by the Korean people (Kang, 2015). In Korea this democratic movement is known under the term *June Uprising* (6월 항쟁) (Lee, 2017).

Ever since the democratization movement there has been an ongoing debate between Korean and international scholars of various fields regarding the question whether Korea's democracy is fully consolidated (Chang, 2022, 2025a, 2025b; Diamond & Kim, 2000; Hahm, 2008; Lee, 2007). This is also due to the fact that there exist different definitions of democratic consolidation, which are largely based on two interpretations of democracy: *minimalist democracy* and *maximalist democracy* (Lee, 2007). While the former position emphasises formal democracy, viewing the merely holding of fair and free elections as the elemental basis of a democratic system, the latter position advocates for a more extensive approach, suggesting that social justice, economic equality and the institutionalization of political institutions should be included in the definition of a fully consolidated democracy (Diamond & Kim, 2000; Lee, 2007). Consequently, Hahm (2008) argues that since the presidential election of 2007, which was won by the conservative candidate Lee Myung-Bak, Korea's democracy can be understood as consolidated. This is because, according to him, this presidential election marked a turning point in the political landscape of Korea since it shifted away from dichotomous topics that used to dominate the Korean political sphere such as regionalism and ideology to concrete themes of welfare and economic growth (Hahm, 2008).

In other words, it was at that time Korea's political landscape started to be more inclusive towards a variety of ideas.

On the other hand, scholars like Chang (2022, 2025a, 2025b) are more sceptical about the contemporary democratic system of Korea. This is because according to him in the case of Korea the development to democracy after its liberation from Japan was not a progress rooted in the ambitions of grassroots citizens but rather a proclamation from political elites (Chang, 2022, 2025a, 2025b). Consequently, although Korea is ruled democratically since the *June Uprising* Chang (2025a) prescribes Korean democracy an elitism, since Korean politics has yet to find a way to meaningfully and systematically represent its people.

Furthermore, recently there has been research emerging about the backsliding of Korea's democracy (Eom & Kwon, 2023; Kwon, 2023; Park, 2025). While there are various forms democratic backsliding can occur in (Bermeo, 2016), Kwon (2023) and Park (2025) explore three major aspects for the Korean-specific context which are populism, technocracy, and far-right ideology. All these three factors were found in the politics of the Yoon Suk-Yeol government, who eventually tried to forcefully take over the country by declaring martial law in the night of December 3rd in 2024 (Cho, 2023; Park, 2025). This incident and through it the rapid spread of far-right forces is drawing attention as a serious threat to Korean democracy, raising important questions about its resilience (Park, 2025; Yang, 2025a, 2025b).

2.2. Korea's Soft Power: From Korean Popular Culture to K-Democracy

Since the late 1990s Korea has established itself as a hub for the production of transnational popular culture, exporting its music, films, TV-shows, games, etc. initially to countries within Asia like Japan and China and recently also to Europe and the United States (Jin, 2023; Kim, 2022). While many factors such as digital technologies and international audiences contribute to the global popularity of the Korean Wave and therefore its soft power, an essential part of it is due to government policies that laid the groundwork for the Korean

cultural industry (Jin, 2023; Kim, 2022). In the mid to late 1990s, after the advent of the Asian Financial crisis, the Korean government under president Kim Young-Sam actively pursued strategies to boost the national economy (Chua & Iwabuchi, 2008; Kim, 2013, 2022). As a result, the government began providing financial support to creative producers of cultural content while simultaneously establishing new laws and regulations which allowed them more freedom (Chua & Iwabuchi, 2008). During that time Korea started to export its locally produced television dramas and films to other Asian countries, resulting in the emergence of the term *Hallyu*, meaning Korean Wave (Jin, 2023; Kim, 2022).

Through the increasing popularity of K-pop (Korean popular music) among a global fandom on various social media platforms the Korean Wave achieved to expand its success beyond Asian countries into Europe and the United States (Jin, 2018; Jin, 2023). Especially the digital evolution of social media and music streaming platforms like YouTube and iTunes have contributed to the global distribution of K-pop, therefore playing a pivotal role in the transcends of Hallyu into local markets outside of East Asia (Ingyu & Hyo-Jung, 2013; Jin & Yoon, 2016).

Nowadays the popularity of Korean cultural content is increasingly driven by the international growth of OTT platforms like Netflix, as they are not only directly involved in the distribution but also in the production of Korean media productions (Dokyung et al., 2021; Jang et al., 2022; Jin, 2023; Jin et al., 2023). As such, globally operating OTT platforms provide audiences around the world an easy access to Korean TV-shows and films (Jin, 2023).

The global popularity of the Korean Wave has been consistently used by the Korean government and its political figures as a strategic tool to achieve foreign policy objectives (Jin, 2023). At the start of the Korean Wave its potential soft power was not yet a focus on a government level (Jin, 2023). However, since the mid-2000s all governments, regardless of

their political orientation, have emphasised the close connection between Hallyu and cultural diplomacy (Jin, 2023). Particularly, former president Lee Myung-Bak focused on Korea's national branding through cultural attractiveness, establishing the Presidential Council for Nation Branding (Jin, 2023). As such, the Korean Wave and the support of its global reach can be seen as an essential part of the cultural politics of Korea (Kim, 2013, 2022). For example, the Moon Jae-In government occasionally involved K-pop stars such as the boy band BTS in high-level state visits abroad (Jin, 2023).

In the case of Europe Cho et al. (2023) analysed the public perception of Korea in Europe by surveying experts in the field of Korean Studies. The dimensions researched included, but were not limited to, economy and development, contemporary culture, and tradition and history (Cho et al., 2023). The study also included German-speaking countries like Germany and Austria and found out that in these countries the perception of Korea's politics was rather low. However, the study failed to explicitly define the questions that were asked regarding Korea's political landscape. Furthermore, since the research participants were experts in the field of Korean Studies, it is very much likely that they have a profound understanding of Korea's politics and history. In other words, it is difficult to say that this study reflects interpretations that can be generalized onto the public of German-speaking countries.

Recently, after the incident of the martial law declaration by former president Yoon Suk-Yeol, which was followed by heavily protests from civilians, the Lee Jae-Myung government started to increasingly using the term K-democracy, which not only reflects the (supposedly) resilience of Korea's democracy, but also should be seen as a beacon of hope and offer valuable lessons to other countries in the global arena (Jeong, 2025, October 25; Kim, 2025, July 14).

2.3. Media Framing of the Martial Law Declaration in English-speaking Newspapers

Entman's (1993) definition of framing is the most widely cited definition of framing. According to Entman (1993), framing involves selecting certain aspects of perceived reality and highlighting them in a text in order to promote a specific problem definition, casual interpretation, moral evaluation or recommendation for action (Entman, 1993). Regarding the Korean martial law incident of early December 2024, this approach enables an analysis of how German-language newspaper positions the Korean democracy and ascribe political values to it.

In the case of the recent incident in Korea, Ha (2025) analysed how international media outlets like the British *The Guardian* and the U.S. *New York Times* reported on the declaration of martial law by former president Yoon Suk-Yeol until his impeachment 122 days after the event, thereby demonstrating how journalism, through investigative and interpretative approaches, shed light on the resilience of the concept of K-democracy. According to him a central theme was the 'domestication' of the news. This means that distant events are often framed in such a way that they reflect the audience's domestic debates (Hafez, 2007). As a result, U.S. newspapers used the crisis in Korea as a warning against their own abuse of power, turning the Korean resistance into a democratic model for readers inside the United states (Ha, 2025).

As already mentioned above, the question of how the notion of K-democracy in conjunction with the martial law incident has been reported by media outlets in German-speaking countries and as extension how the popularity of the Korean Wave inside these countries influences this perception has been an understudied topic.

Thus, this study explores how Austrian, German, and Swiss newspapers framed the martial law incident and how the popularity of Korean media products shapes the interpretation of K-democracy inside these countries.

Therefore, following research questions are proposed:

RQ1: *How do German-speaking newspaper frame the reporting of the martial law incident in Korea?*

RQ2: *How do people from Austria, Germany and Swiss interpret Korea's democracy through Korean popular culture?*

RQ3: *How experiences of Korean popular culture influence the notion of K-democracy?*

3. Research Method:

This study draws on qualitative research methods to explore how Korea's notion of K-democracy is represented and interpreted in German-speaking countries. For RQ1 both qualitative content analysis and qualitative discourse analysis will be employed to analyse media frames and discourse in newspaper articles. For RQ2 semi-structured interviews will be conducted in order to examine how people in German-speaking countries interpret Korea's cultural content and its democracy. Lastly, for RQ3 this study tries to examine how the popularity of Korea's media products influences the interpretation of Korea's democracy.

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